

Two Men, One Gospel

A long manuscript for reduction to 30 minutes

Texts: 2 Timothy 4:9-11; Colossians 4:14; Philemon 1:24; Revelation 2:4-5 **Title:** Two Men, One Gospel: Demas, Luke, and the Question of First Love

Church family, I want to invite you into a very small scene in Scripture that carries an enormous weight.

It is late in Paul's life. He is in prison again. This is not the earlier season of house arrest with greater freedom. This is the darker hour. The letter of 2 Timothy has the feel of farewell. It is warm, urgent, personal, and shadowed by the nearness of death.

Then, in that final letter, Paul begins naming names.

"Do thy diligence to come shortly unto me: for Demas hath forsaken me, having loved this present world, and is departed unto Thessalonica... only Luke is with me."

Only a few words. But in those few words there is a whole sermon.

Two men. One gospel. One apostle. One difficult hour. One of them leaves. One of them stays.

And the difference is not intelligence. It is not gifting. It is not access. It is not whether one man had heard more sermons than the other. It is not whether one understood doctrine and the other did not. The difference, finally, is the direction of love.

Demas loved this present world.

Luke remained.

And I want to suggest this morning that the story of Demas is not in the Bible merely so that we can shake our heads at someone else's failure. It is in the Bible so that the church can examine the movement of its own heart.

Because the deepest spiritual danger is not always open rebellion. Sometimes it is respectable activity with cooling affection. Sometimes it is continuing to stand near the work while quietly drifting from Christ.

That is what makes Demas frightening. He does not appear in Scripture first as a villain. He appears as a companion.

In Colossians 4:14, Paul says, "Luke, the beloved physician, and Demas, greet you."

In Philemon 1:24, Paul calls Demas one of his "fellow labourers."

Do not miss what that means. Demas was not on the edge of the movement. He was not a casual observer. He was inside the circle. He had proximity to Paul, proximity to mission, proximity to suffering, proximity to gospel labor.

He had a good beginning.

And then 2 Timothy 4:10 tells us the ending of the visible story:

"Demas hath forsaken me, having loved this present world."

Paul does not say Demas became an atheist. He does not say Demas cursed the church. He does not say Demas openly embraced a life of scandal. He says Demas loved something else more.

That is the charge.

Misplaced affection.

Disordered love.

The heart moving away before the feet ever do.

As a physician, I think one of the most useful distinctions here is the difference between an acute event and a chronic condition. There are things that happen suddenly, dramatically, visibly. And then there are conditions that progress quietly. One day the patient is not well, but the problem did not begin that day. It has been building. It has been advancing. It has been doing its work beneath the surface long before anyone called it by its name.

Demas, I think, is not an acute collapse. He is a chronic condition of the soul.

He did not leave the work first. He left his love first.

That is why his story is so close to ours.

Because many of us are not being tempted right now by dramatic, public, spectacular sin. We are being tempted by a quieter exchange. We are being tempted to give our deepest affection to things that can be admired in public.

Career.

Security.

Recognition.

Comfort.

Professional identity.

The preservation of self.

The management of a respectable life.

And here is what makes the temptation especially subtle for serious Christians: many of these things are not evil in themselves. Work is not evil. Responsibility is not evil. Planning is not evil. Even ambition, rightly ordered, can be harnessed toward faithful stewardship. The problem comes when good things move too close to the center, until Christ is no longer first.

Demas did not need to run into obvious wickedness in order to drift. He only needed to love this present age more than he loved Christ.

And the phrase Paul uses is striking: "this present world," or more literally, this present age. That means the spirit of the age. The values of the age. The safety offered by the age. The rewards offered by the age. The emotional logic of the age.

Demas wanted what the age gives.

And that has not changed very much.

For some of us, the age offers speed.

For some, it offers approval.

For some, it offers the pleasure of being needed.

For some, it offers the confidence that comes from competence.

For some, it offers the relief of being admired.

For some, it offers the safety of not standing too close to costly faithfulness.

The point is not that every believer is tempted in the same way. The point is that every age has a vocabulary of seduction, and if we do not keep returning to Christ, the vocabulary of the age will begin to sound normal to us.

This age still makes offers.

It offers the dignity of visible success without the cost of deep surrender. It offers the comfort of respectability without the risk of wholehearted devotion. It offers enough religion to preserve appearance, but not enough Christ to disturb ambition.

So Demas is not ancient in the way we sometimes imagine ancient people to be. Demas is modern. Demas is contemporary. Demas is frighteningly understandable.

Ellen White says in *The Acts of the Apostles* that Demas was steadfast for a time, but afterward forsook the cause of Christ, and for worldly gain bartered every high and noble consideration. That is exactly right. Demas made an exchange. He traded the eternal for the immediate. He traded a costly faithfulness for a manageable life.

And that exchange always looks reasonable in the short term.

That is why it is dangerous.

No one drifts by accident alone. We drift because the drift begins to feel justified.

We say, just for this season.

We say, once things settle down.

We say, I will get back to prayer when the pressure is less.

We say, I still believe; I am only busy.

We say, I have not abandoned Christ; I am simply building what needs to be built.

And slowly, the soul gets thinner.

The devotional life becomes hurried.

Prayer becomes occasional instead of necessary.

Scripture becomes familiar but not alive.

Worship becomes attended but not inhabited.

We remain near the work, but far from warmth.

Ellen White describes something close to this in *Testimonies for the Church*, volume 5, when she warns that many have only hurried prayer and no real communion with God. That is not a description of atheists. That is a description of respectable believers whose inner life has become starved.

And that is why Demas belongs in a church sermon.

Not because we are all planning to become public deserters.

But because any church full of active people is in danger of losing the tenderness of first love.

And let me say this in a very practical way.

There is a form of worldliness that does not look worldly at first glance. It can wear Christian language. It can be wrapped in ministry language. It can hide inside the vocabulary of responsibility. It says:

I am only working hard.

I am only trying to provide.

I am only trying to build something meaningful.

I am only trying to be excellent.

And again, none of those statements are automatically false. But if excellence becomes identity, if provision becomes self-salvation, if usefulness becomes the measure of worth, then the soul is already in danger.

That is why Demas is not merely a warning to reckless people. He is a warning to competent people.

He is a warning to sincere people.

He is a warning to those of us who know how to stay busy enough that no one asks deeper questions.

He is a warning to all who know how to maintain the appearance of faithfulness after the inward music has quieted.

That brings us to the contrast.

Because in the same final roll call where Demas departs, Luke remains.

"Only Luke is with me."

Those are beautiful words.

And we should not rush past them.

Luke is mentioned earlier in Colossians as "the beloved physician." That means skill. It means education. It means usefulness. It means the kind of identity that could easily have produced a comfortable and respected life.

Luke had options.

That matters.

His faithfulness is not impressive because he had nowhere else to go. It is impressive because he could have gone elsewhere and did not.

When the cost rose, Luke stayed.

When Paul's circumstances became socially dangerous, Luke stayed.

When the room emptied, Luke stayed.

When imprisonment became damp, dark, humiliating, and uncertain, Luke stayed.

Ellen White says of this moment that the services of Luke, the beloved physician and faithful friend, were a great comfort to Paul. I love that phrase: faithful friend.

Not celebrity.

Not platform.

Not prominence.

Faithful friend.

Luke shows us a kind of discipleship that does not always make noise. It is the discipleship of presence. The discipleship of endurance. The discipleship that is still in the room when excitement is gone and the risk is real.

And church family, do not underestimate the power of that kind of faithfulness.

There are moments in the Christian life when one faithful presence becomes the mercy of God to a suffering person.

Paul says, "Only Luke is with me."

That means that in one of the most difficult moments of the apostle's life, the whole body of Christ was, in a sense, embodied for him in the steadfast presence of one disciple.

Luke was not the whole church.

But in that moment, he represented the church's tenderness.

He represented the church's courage.

He represented the church's refusal to disappear when suffering became inconvenient.

And I think that matters for a local congregation. Because many people do not need us only when life is easy. They need a Luke when the room gets quiet. They need a Luke when the diagnosis is hard. They need a Luke when grief empties the calendar and leaves only loneliness. They need a Luke when the prison is not literal but emotional, spiritual, or physical.

The world notices dramatic leadership. Heaven notices faithful presence.

And there is a second reason Luke matters here. Luke did not only stay physically near Paul. He also preserved for the church some of the clearest words of Jesus about discipleship.

It is Luke who records, "If any man will come after me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross daily, and follow me."

It is Luke who records some of the strongest teachings about the cost of following Christ.

And in Paul's final hour, Luke lives what he wrote.

That is a beautiful thing.

Luke did not merely write the theology of discipleship. He practiced it.

He did not merely preserve Jesus' call to self-denial. He answered it.

He did not only tell the church what costly love sounds like. He showed the church what costly love looks like.

And that is why Luke is such a powerful contrast to Demas.

Both men heard the gospel.

Both men served near Paul.

Both men knew what the mission cost.

Both men stood in the same age.

But one loved the age, and the other loved Christ.

And that contrast brings us to a question Jesus asked Peter in John 21. After failure, after grief, after confusion, after resurrection, Jesus does not first ask Peter, Are you stronger now? He does not ask, Are you more disciplined now? He does not ask, Are you prepared now for greater usefulness?

He asks, "Lovest thou me?"

That is the issue.

Because Jesus knows what we sometimes try not to know: love sits underneath endurance. Love sits underneath obedience. Love sits underneath sacrifice. Eventually, the heart will follow what it treasures most.

That is why Matthew 6:21 is not sentimental but diagnostic: "Where your treasure is, there will your heart be also."

The heart follows treasure.

The soul bends toward what it prizes.

That means our schedules reveal something. Our anxieties reveal something. Our fantasies reveal something. What we protect most fiercely reveals something. What we cannot imagine surrendering reveals something.

And the Christian life is not merely a struggle to do the right things. It is a grace-enabled reordering of love.

Now let me widen the lens, because Demas is not just an individual biography. He is also a warning to the church.

In Revelation 2, Christ speaks to the church at Ephesus. And what He says there should make every serious congregation tremble just a little.

He says, I know thy works.

I know thy labor.

I know thy patience.

I know that thou canst not bear them which are evil.

I know that thou hast tested false apostles.

I know that thou hast borne and hast not fainted.

In other words, this is a strong church.

A working church.

A discerning church.

A persevering church.

An orthodox church.

And then Christ says, "Nevertheless I have somewhat against thee, because thou hast left thy first love."

That is one of the most searching sentences in all of Scripture.

Because it tells us that activity is not the same thing as affection.

It tells us that doctrinal seriousness is not the same thing as nearness to Christ.

It tells us that it is possible to be right in argument and cooling in devotion.

It tells us that one can do the work of the church while gradually losing the warmth of love for the Lord of the church.

That is why I want to say something very plainly this morning: you do not have to leave the church to leave your first love.

You can keep your office.

You can keep your role.

You can keep your schedule.

You can keep your public usefulness.

And still be drifting.

Demas is what Revelation 2 looks like in a single life.

Ellen White describes the church's decline in *The Acts of the Apostles* by saying that gradually the believers began to dwell on defects, give place to criticism, and lose sight of the Saviour and His love. That is an extraordinary line. They lost sight of the Saviour and His love.

That is always the real crisis.

When Christ becomes less vivid, something else becomes more compelling.

When Christ becomes less beautiful, other loves begin to feel more urgent.

When communion becomes thin, substitutes begin to look nourishing.

And when that happens, we may still be religious, but we are no longer alive in the deepest sense.

And this is one reason the Revelation 2 diagnosis matters so much for Adventists and for all serious Christians. It exposes a very uncomfortable possibility: orthodoxy can coexist with coldness. Correctness can coexist with distance. A church can preserve structure, doctrine, and labor while losing the sweetness that first made obedience joyful.

So when Jesus says, "Remember," He is not speaking to theological liberals. He is speaking to believers who still have many things right.

That should humble all of us.

Because a congregation can keep its forms and still need revival.

A family can keep its routines and still need revival.

A preacher can keep preaching and still need revival.

A physician can keep serving and still need revival.

A young adult can keep attending and still need revival.

An elder can keep leading and still need revival.

No one in the room is automatically exempt from the possibility of first-love drift.

So what is the answer?

Christ gives the answer to Ephesus in three words: remember, repent, return.

Remember from where you have fallen.

Repent.

Do the first works.

That means the solution is not to become more frantic. It is not merely to become more active. It is not to pile more church tasks onto a cooling heart. It is to return to the center.

To remember what Christ was to us when love was warm.

To repent of every substitute we have allowed to occupy too much space.

To return to the practices and posture of first love.

That includes prayer that is no longer hurried.

That includes Scripture not merely studied, but received.

That includes confession without excuse.

That includes worship that is no longer managed like performance.

That includes saying to the Lord, with honesty, something like this: I have been more stirred by lesser things than by Your presence. I have guarded my ambitions better than I have guarded my heart. I have not openly denied You, but I have given too much room to what is passing away. Lord, return me to Yourself.

And here, church family, is where I think our Adventist faith has a gift to offer, not only to the world but to our own souls.

The Sabbath.

The Sabbath is not only a doctrine to defend. It is a grace to receive.

The Sabbath is God's weekly interruption of false worship.

Every week the world trains us to measure ourselves by output, speed, accumulation, and control. Every week the age whispers that we are what we produce. Every week we are invited to build an identity out of labor, status, performance, and visibility.

Then the Sabbath arrives and says: stop.

Stop producing yourself.

Stop proving yourself.

Stop pretending the world rests on your effort.

Stop acting as though salvation can be managed by schedule and strain.

Remember your Creator.

Remember your Redeemer.

Remember that you are a child before you are a producer.

Remember that you are loved before you are impressive.

Remember also that the Sabbath says two things at once. In Exodus it reminds us that we are creatures, not gods. In Deuteronomy it reminds us that we are redeemed people, not slaves. That means every

Sabbath is a protest against self-creation and a protest against slavery.

You do not create yourself.

And you do not save yourself.

That is why Sabbath is such a needed answer to the Demas problem. Demas was pulled by what the age rewards. Sabbath trains the heart to love what the Kingdom rewards.

That is why I want to put it this way this morning: the Sabbath is God's built-in resistance against becoming Demas.

It is not a rule meant to burden the faithful.

It is a rescue meant to reorder the faithful.

Ellen White says that we are not merely to observe the Sabbath as a legal matter, but to understand its spiritual bearing upon all the transactions of life. That is a needed word. Sabbath is not just one day correctly managed. Sabbath is the weekly restoration of right love.

It interrupts identity through achievement.

It interrupts the quiet replacement of God by good things.

It interrupts the illusion that usefulness is the same thing as holiness.

And it recenters:

Relationship over performance.

Trust over productivity.

Presence over frenzy.

Delight over mere duty.

And notice how Isaiah speaks about it: "Call the sabbath a delight." Not merely a duty, not merely a boundary, not merely an identity marker in public controversy, but a delight. That means the Sabbath is not only about what we stop doing. It is about whom we enjoy again.

The deepest Sabbath question is not only, Did I stop my regular labor? The deeper question is, Did my heart come home to God?

Did I rest in His sufficiency?

Did I delight in His presence?

Did I allow the Lord to expose what had become too central in me during the week?

That is why I sometimes think the weekly arrival of Sabbath is a mercy for souls like ours. It comes every seven days to interrupt our illusions and say: you are drifting toward becoming what you worship. Turn again. Come back. Breathe. Delight yourself in the Lord.

This matters especially in a congregation like ours, where many people know how to work, how to build, how to serve, how to carry responsibility. Those are good things. But the very strengths that make a congregation useful can also become the strengths through which the soul is tempted.

So let us be clear: the call of this sermon is not laziness. It is rightly ordered devotion.

The problem with Demas was not that he was active. The problem was what he loved while he was active.

That is the issue.

So I want to ask you, gently but directly:

What is competing with Christ for your deepest affection right now?

What good thing has moved too close to the throne?

What have you been protecting more anxiously than your communion with God?

What have you been pursuing so intensely that prayer now feels like interruption rather than oxygen?

And if someone wrote one sentence about your spiritual life five years from now, would it sound more like Colossians 4 or 2 Timothy 4?

Would it say that you were present, trusted, laboring in the gospel?

Or would it say that you loved this present world?

Would your children say they saw in you warmth toward Jesus, or only religious seriousness?

Would your spouse say Christ was truly central, or only verbally central?

Would your private life confirm your public profession?

Would the people closest to you say they have seen in you the tenderness of first love?

Please hear me carefully: this is not a sermon of hopelessness. Because Demas is not the only name in the text.

Luke is there too.

Luke stayed.

Luke remained useful because Luke remained anchored.

Luke was not sinless, but he was steady.

Luke was not dramatic, but he was faithful.

Luke was not merely orthodox, but present.

Luke wrote about Christ and stayed with Christ's servant when it hurt.

And the same Christ who held Luke can hold us.

You do not overcome the Demas temptation by self-reproach alone. You overcome it by seeing Christ again as better.

That is why one of the finest lines in *Steps to Christ* says that when the love of Christ rules the heart, duty becomes a delight and sacrifice a pleasure. That is not describing a grim, clenched spirituality. It is describing love rightly ordered.

When Christ is first, obedience is not emptied of cost, but it is filled with meaning.

When Christ is first, sacrifice is still sacrifice, but it is no longer absurd.

When Christ is first, the world does not lose all attractiveness because the world becomes ugly. The world loses its power because Christ becomes more beautiful.

That is the invitation this morning.

Not simply to fear Demas.

But to love Christ.

To remember.

To repent.

To return.

To receive the Sabbath as rescue.

To let the heart be reordered.

To let devotion deepen again.

To ask for more than respectable religion.

To ask for first love.

And so I close with this:

Paul's final attendance list is still speaking.

Demas left.

Luke stayed.

The age was costly for both men.

The gospel was the same for both men.

The difference was love.

May it not be said of us that we were near the work but far from Christ.

May it be said that in a distracted age, in a pressured age, in an ambitious age, we loved Him first.

And if the drift has already begun, then do not wait for catastrophe.

Return now.

Return while the voice of Christ is still tenderly saying, remember.

Return while the Spirit still awakens hunger.

Return while the Sabbath still opens space for delight.

Return while grace is still inviting you home.

And if you return, you will find that Christ receives returning people. That is the hope of the gospel. Peter returned. Mark returned. The church at Ephesus was called to return. Christ does not expose first-love drift in order to mock us. He exposes it in order to heal us.

So if the Spirit has named something in you this morning, do not harden. Do not explain it away. Do not call it maturity when it is really cooling. Do not call it busyness when it is really neglect. Do not call it responsibility when it is really replacement.

Bring it to Christ.

Bring Him the heart itself.

Bring Him the disordered love.

Bring Him the overgrown ambition.

Bring Him the fatigue that has hidden self-reliance.

Bring Him the fear that has made you cling too tightly to what this age offers.

And ask Him to make you alive again.

Luke stayed.

By the grace of Christ, so can you.

Amen.